

Emissions down 44% per person, 80% per unit of GDP?

*Testing Malta's COP30 statement on emissions
against Eurostat data*

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“Malta has already reduced its per capita emissions by over 44% compared to 2005 and emissions per unit of GDP by more than 80%.”

Government of Malta, COP30 national statement, November 2025.

Delivered on behalf of the Minister for the Environment, Energy and Public Cleanliness.

VERDICT: LARGELY SUPPORTED

The 80% holds only at current prices; about 70% in real terms

Version 1.2 · 6 October 2026

Status: no right of reply needed

Prepared from public sources and Eurostat data.

Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT

Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

In its statement to the COP30 high-level segment (November 2025), the Government of Malta said: **“Malta has already reduced its per capita emissions by over 44% compared to 2005 and emissions per unit of GDP by more than 80%, demonstrating our commitment to decoupling growth from emissions.”** We tested both figures against Eurostat’s greenhouse-gas inventory, GDP and population series.

- 1

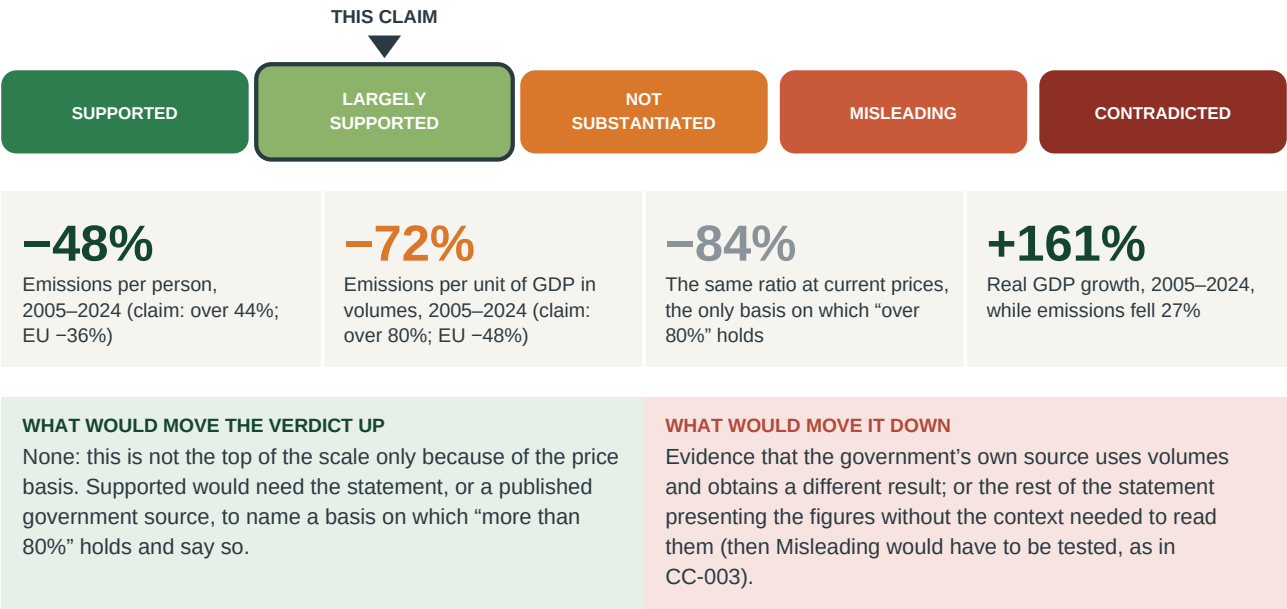
The 44% figure is right. Eurostat gives –46% to 2023 (the latest year available when the statement was made) and –48.5% to 2024; the EU average is –34% and –36%. Malta passed –44% in 2016. Population growth of 41% explains about half of it (see CC-003).
- 2

The “more than 80%” figure depends on the price basis, which the statement does not give. Against GDP at current prices, Malta’s emissions intensity fell 82% to 2023 and 84% to 2024. Against GDP in chain-linked volumes, the usual way to compare intensity over time, it fell 70% and 72%. No year to 2024 reaches –80% in volumes. The gap is a price effect: Malta’s GDP deflator rose about 72%.
- 3

The decoupling claim holds. Real GDP grew 161% between 2005 and 2024 while total emissions fell 27%: absolute decoupling, which the research literature calls rare [8]. Most of the fall came from power generation (CC-003).
- 4

What the sentence does not say. Total emissions fell less than the EU average (–27% against –33%), and CC-003 shows that Malta’s emissions in the sectors under its binding 2030 target are above their 2005 level. We have read only the quoted paragraph of the statement, not the rest, so we cannot say whether it addresses this elsewhere.
- 5

Verdict: largely supported (moderate confidence). The substance, strong decoupling, is backed by the data. The headline “80%” holds only at current prices; in volumes it is about 70%.



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1 The claim and what we could verify

The wording comes from “COP30 Malta National Statement” on the UNFCCC site [1] (a Word document behind a .pdf address). **The wording is the paragraph supplied by the maintainer on 5 October 2026** and recorded in *literature/CC-025/primary-source.md*; the supplied text covers the opening line and the paragraph quoted above. Our own download of the file was refused by a bot check: on 6 October 2026 the address still returned a 212-byte HTML page, not the document. We therefore could not check the wording against the file ourselves. The statement was delivered on behalf of Malta’s Minister for the Environment, Energy and Public Cleanliness; the text we have does not name the person who read it, so we attribute it to the Government of Malta.

TWO THINGS WE COULD NOT SETTLE

(1) The wording is not independently verified against the UNFCCC file (see above). (2) The statement gives no year, so the choice of 2023 and 2024 is ours: 2023 was the latest inventory year available in November 2025, and 2024 is the latest in the current data. Both are shown throughout.

Source	What it says	Our access	Status
Government of Malta , COP30 national statement, Nov 2025 [1]	“Importantly, Malta has already reduced its per capita emissions by over 44% compared to 2005 and emissions per unit of GDP by more than 80%, demonstrating our commitment to decoupling growth from emissions.”	The paragraph, as supplied by the maintainer (5 Oct 2026); our download was refused. Rest of the statement not read.	The claim
Climate Action Authority , press release, 13 Nov 2025 (CC-003) [2]	Per-capita fall of 44% (EU 34%); emissions per unit of GDP down 81.6% (EU 61.9%). Different speaker, same figures, same week.	Read in CC-003 (Wayback copy).	Context
Eurostat , env_air_gge, nama_10_gdp, nama_10_pe [3–5]	Emissions inventory, GDP in current prices and chain-linked volumes, population.	Downloaded 5 Oct 2026 (data/cc-025/).	Primary data

RELATION TO CC-003

CC-003 checked the same 44% figure in the Climate Action Authority’s release and rated that release *Misleading* because it left out the Commission’s 2030 projection for the same report. This check is separate: a different speaker and setting (a statement to a UN conference), and a second figure (intensity per unit of GDP). For the per-person figure we reuse CC-003’s data and analysis and do not repeat them in full.

2 Method

Question. Are the two figures accurate, and does the sentence fairly describe “decoupling growth from emissions”?

Evidence. The test is statistical. On 5 October 2026 we downloaded Eurostat’s greenhouse-gas inventory (env_air_gge, total excluding land use and international transport, 1990–2024), GDP (nama_10_gdp, current prices and chain-linked volumes at 2020 prices) and population (nama_10_pe) for Malta and the EU-27 (*tools/cc-025-report/fetch.py*), and recomputed every percentage with a script (*calc.py*; outputs in *data/cc-025/checks.csv*). No Eurostat status flags apply to the Malta values used. The statement gives no year and no GDP basis; we report 2023 (the last inventory year available in November 2025) and 2024. The 2024 emissions file is the same vintage as CC-003’s.

Why the GDP basis matters. Emissions per unit of GDP divides emissions by GDP. If GDP is measured in current prices, inflation inflates the denominator and the ratio falls faster than the economy’s real efficiency improves. Comparing intensity over time is normally done in volumes (prices of a fixed year), so that only real output is counted. Both are computable; they give different numbers.

Grades. Official statistics are grade C in our scale; the one peer-reviewed review used [8] is grade C (review) and is read as an abstract. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3 What the data show

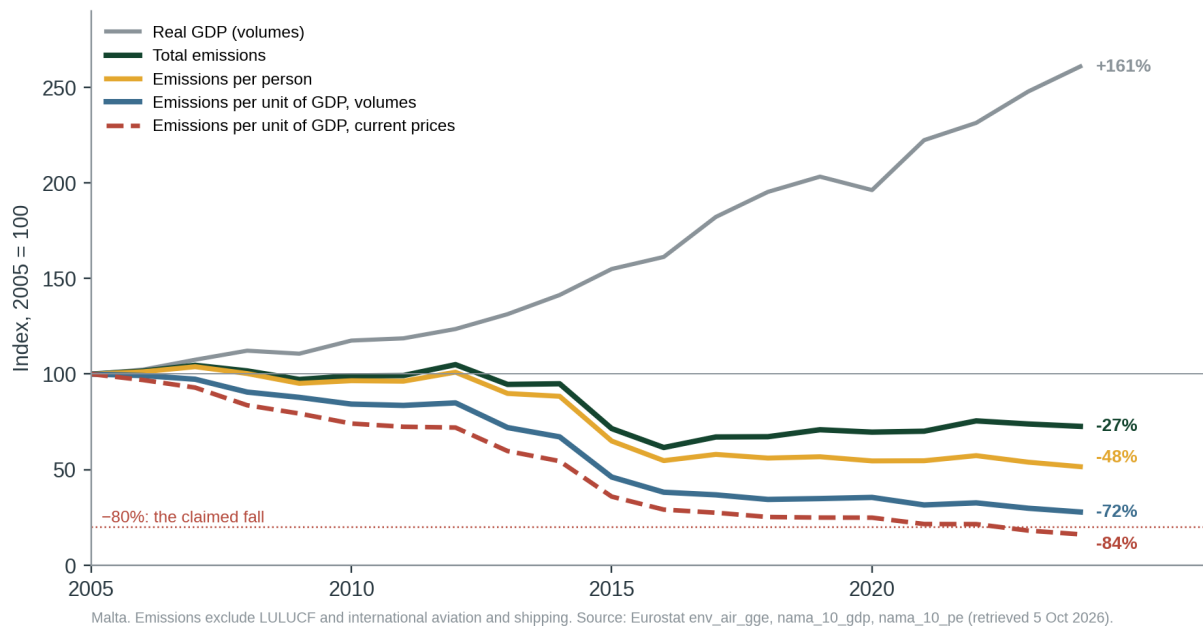


Figure 1. Malta, indexed to 2005: real GDP, total emissions, emissions per person and emissions per unit of GDP on two bases. Only the dashed current-price line passes the –80% mark.

Malta's real GDP grew 161% from 2005 to 2024, its population 41% and its total emissions fell 27%. Per person that is –48.5% (EU –36%), matching “over 44%”. Per unit of GDP it is –72% in volumes (EU –48%) and –84% at current prices (EU –65%). In 2023, the year the statement could have used, the figures are –70% and –82% (EU –46% and –62%).

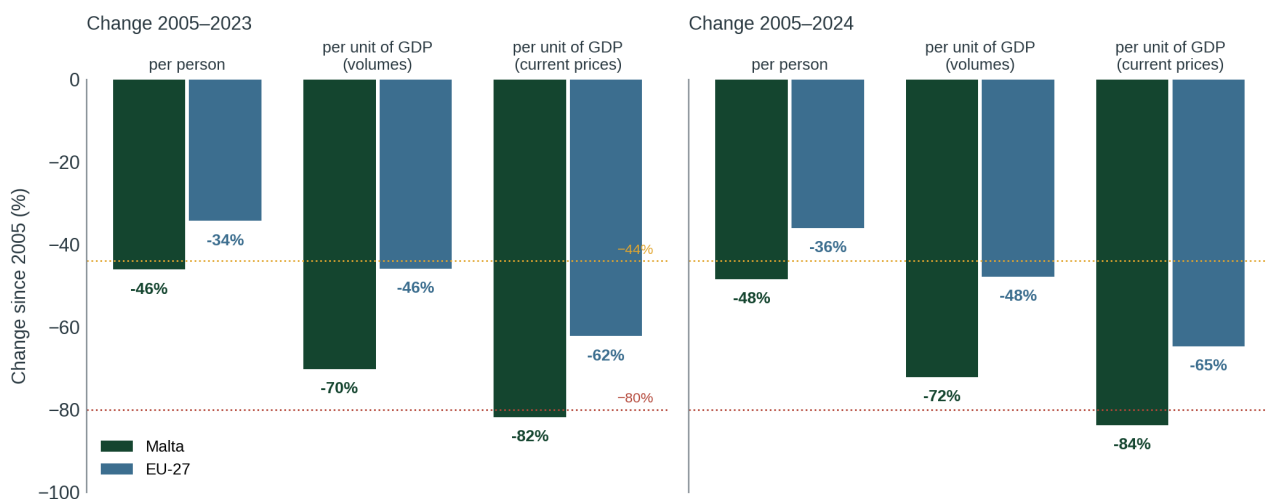


Figure 2. The three measures, Malta and EU-27, to 2023 and 2024. Dotted lines mark the claimed –44% and –80%.

The Climate Action Authority's “81.6% (EU 61.9%)” [2] is close to our current-price results for 2023 (–81.9%, EU –62.2%), which suggests the same basis. That is our inference; neither document states the basis.

WHY THE TWO INTENSITY FIGURES DIFFER

Malta's nominal GDP rose 350% from 2005 to 2024, its real GDP 161%. The ratio of the two (the implicit GDP price level) rose 72%. On a logarithmic split, about 30% of the current-price intensity fall is the price effect; the rest is real. The EU-27 price level rose 48% over the same period, so the comparison with the EU holds on either basis: Malta's intensity fell more.

4

Where the evidence points different ways

Is “decoupling growth from emissions” fair?		LARGELY YES
EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM Real GDP +161% while total emissions –27% (2005–2024). Absolute decoupling in this sense is unusual in the literature [8 ♦].	CAVEATS The fall is concentrated in one step: after the 2015 interconnector and gas conversion (CC-003), total emissions reached a low in 2016 and have since risen 18% to 2024 (calc.py). Total emissions fell less than the EU average (–27% vs –33%). Emissions in the sectors under the national target are not falling (CC-003). Production-based inventory only: it excludes international aviation and shipping and emissions embodied in imports.	
WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE Both sides are accurate. “Decoupling” is a statement about GDP and emissions together, and the data show it. It is not a statement about the 2030 target, so the second column limits how far the sentence can be read, not whether it is true.		

The same period on the residence basis. The statement counts territorial emissions (UNFCCC inventory basis) and says so by implication; this report uses that basis throughout. Eurostat’s air emissions accounts count emissions of Malta-resident units instead, including international aviation fuel bought abroad. On that basis (env_ac_ainah_r2, all activities and households, per person using nama_10_pe) Malta’s emissions per person *rose* 69% from 2013 to 2024 (7.2 to 12.2 t CO₂e; the 2024 value is flagged imputed), the largest rise of the 27 Member States (rank 27 of 27; the EU-27 fell 21%; four others also rose, Lithuania next at +18.5%). Total residence-basis emissions rose 126% against population +34%. This does not contradict the statement, which is about the territorial inventory and a different start year (2005; this series begins in our extract at 2013), and it is why we keep *Largely supported*. It is context a reader needs: the territorial fall and the residence-basis rise are both real. CC-114 differs because it draws a causal inference from the residence-basis series that the data contradict. Data: `data/cc-025/residence_basis_per_person.csv`.

5 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	Said by	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. Per-capita emissions down over 44% since 2005	Govt of Malta [1]	Reproduced from Eurostat: –46% to 2023, –48.5% to 2024; Malta passed –44% in 2016. The same figure was checked in CC-003. About half of it is population growth.	ACCURATE
B. Emissions per unit of GDP down more than 80%	Govt of Malta [1]	Holds at current prices (–82% to 2023, –84% to 2024). In chain-linked volumes it is –70% and –72%; no year reaches –80%. The statement names neither basis.	TRUE ONLY AT CURRENT PRICES
C. ...demonstrating our commitment to decoupling growth from emissions	Govt of Malta [1]	Real GDP +161%, total emissions –27%: absolute decoupling over 2005–2024. A statement of commitment is not itself testable; the data show the decoupling it refers to.	SUPPORTED

6 Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

The substance, strong decoupling, is backed by the data; the “80%” holds only at current prices. Confidence: moderate.

Why. (1) The 44% figure is accurate and matches Eurostat and CC-003. (2) The “more than 80%” figure is reproducible only with GDP at current prices; in volumes the fall is about 70–72%. That is a caveat on the size of the figure, not on its direction: Malta’s intensity fell much more than the EU’s on either basis. (3) Real GDP more than doubled while emissions fell, which is the decoupling the sentence describes. We rate the whole claim *Largely supported* rather than *Supported* because the headline figure is stated without the basis it needs, and it overstates the fall by about ten points on the usual basis. Confidence is moderate because we have read the supplied paragraph only, and the statement’s own source and method are not published.

Why a ten-point overstatement is a minor caveat under the scale. The scale reserves *Not substantiated*, *Misleading* and *Contradicted* for claims whose central figure fails, or whose framing would leave a reader with a wrong picture. Here the 44% figure is right, the decoupling the sentence draws from it holds (real GDP +161%, emissions –27%), and “more than 80%” is reproducible from Eurostat on a stated, computable basis (current prices: –82% and –84%). The shortfall in volumes (–70% and –72%, so 8 to 10 points below the claim) changes the size of one figure, not the conclusion that Malta’s intensity fell steeply and faster than the EU’s on either basis. What would have made this *Not substantiated*: no basis, in any year, on which the figure could be reproduced; or evidence that the government’s own source uses volumes and obtains a different result. We also keep this consistent with CC-003, which rated the Climate Action Authority’s release *Misleading* on a different ground (it left out the Commission’s 2030 projection), not on the accuracy of these figures.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say Malta is on course for its 2030 target, which is a separate question (CC-003: *Misleading* for the authority’s release, which left out the projection; CC-094; CC-011). It does not say anyone chose the current-price basis to flatter the result: we found no document stating the basis. A fuller statement would read: “Emissions per person fell 44% and per unit of GDP about 70% in real terms, while real GDP more than doubled; total emissions fell 27%.”

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ The source and method for “over 44%” and “more than 80%”, including the year, the emissions scope and whether GDP is in current prices or volumes.

- ☐ The full text of the statement, to check whether it mentions the 2030 effort-sharing projection.
- ☐ The name of the person who delivered the statement, if it is to be attributed beyond the Government of Malta.

RIGHT OF REPLY

Not needed for this verdict (maintainer rule of 5 October 2026: a reply is sought only for *Not substantiated*, *Misleading* or *Contradicted*). The requests above remain open to the Environment Ministry and the Climate Action Authority.

7

Limitations

- We read only the paragraph supplied by the maintainer; our own download of the UNFCCC file was refused by a bot check (on 6 October 2026 it still returned a 212-byte HTML page). The wording is therefore not independently verified against the file, and other parts of the statement may qualify or add to it.
- The statement gives no year, scope or GDP basis. The choice of 2023 and 2024 is our assumption (2023 was the latest inventory year in November 2025); we report both, and the Eurostat total excluding land use and international transport (TOTX4_MEMO). Eurostat’s other total (TOTXMEMO) changes Malta’s intensity results by 0.1 point or less (EU-27: up to 0.8 points).
- Eurostat’s 2026 inventory may differ slightly from the national submission behind the statement.
- The literature [8] was read as an abstract only; it is context for the word “decoupling”, not evidence for the figures.
- Production-based emissions only: emissions embodied in imports and international aviation and shipping are outside the series.

References

- [1] Government of Malta (Nov 2025). COP30 Malta National Statement, high-level segment. UNFCCC. (Quoted paragraph as supplied by the maintainer, 5 Oct 2026; file is a Word document behind a .pdf address.)
https://unfccc.int/sites/default/files/resource/MALTA_cop30cmp20cma7_HLS_ENG.pdf
- [2] Climate Action Authority (13 Nov 2025). Malta strengthens its contribution toward the EU's climate goals. Press release (read in CC-003 from a Wayback copy). <https://climateaction.gov.mt/press/malta-strengthens-its-contribution-toward-the-eus-climate-goals/>
- [3] Eurostat. Greenhouse gas emissions by source sector (env_air_gge), retrieved 5 Oct 2026.
https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/env_air_gge/default/table
- [4] Eurostat. GDP and main components (nama_10_gdp), updated 2 Oct 2026, retrieved 5 Oct 2026.
https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/nama_10_gdp/default/table
- [5] Eurostat. Population and employment (nama_10_pe), retrieved 5 Oct 2026.
https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/nama_10_pe/default/table
- [6] Miżien. CC-003 report and data (per-person figure, 2030 projection): claims/CC-003; data/cc-003/.
- [7] Miżien. Calculation script and outputs: tools/cc-025-report/calc.py; data/cc-025/checks.csv; residence-basis figures: tools/cc-025-report/residence_basis.py; data/cc-025/residence_basis_per_person.csv (Eurostat env_ac_ainah_r2, nama_10_pe, retrieved 6 Oct 2026).
- [8] Haberl H. et al. (2020). A systematic review of the evidence on decoupling of GDP, resource use and GHG emissions, part II: synthesizing the insights. *Environmental Research Letters* 15(6):065003. doi:10.1088/1748-9326/ab842a. (Abstract read; open access, CC BY.) <https://doi.org/10.1088/1748-9326/ab842a>

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	5 Oct 2026	First issue. Verdict Largely supported (moderate confidence); no right of reply needed.
1.1	6 Oct 2026	Corrections after audit: explained in section 6 why the roughly ten-point overstatement in volumes is a minor caveat and what would make the claim Not substantiated; recorded consistently that the wording is the maintainer-supplied paragraph and our own UNFCCC download was refused (HTML page returned on 6 Oct); stated the year choice as our assumption. Verdict unchanged; no right of reply needed.
1.2	6 Oct 2026	Added a paragraph in section 4 on the residence basis (Eurostat air emissions accounts): per-person emissions +69% 2013-2024, rank 27 of 27, so that the territorial basis of the statement is set beside it; cross-reference to CC-114. Verdict, confidence and sub-claim ratings unchanged; no right of reply needed.